Ancient stromatolites

☞ **1** Use the word bank to complete the passage below.

Word bank					
fossil	extinct	algae	seen	period	stromatolites
ago	limit	salt	beds	populated	layered
world	million	marine	water		

Most organisms that p_____ the Earth millions of years ago are now e_____. Modern plants and animals have only been around for the last few m_____ years.

One organism that was common throughout the world in the **Precambrian** p_____, more than 570 million years a____, was the **stromatolite**. Stromatolites are thought to be a major part of the f_____ record for the first 3.5 billion years of life on Earth. Stromatolites are l_____ growing structures formed in shallow s_____ water. Microorganisms such as **cyanobacteria**, also known as blue-green a_____, form these growths by binding and cementing grains of sand to themselves. Over time the **microorganisms** build little mounds or b_____ in the water.

Most s_____ have vanished from the Earth and can only be s____ as fossils. However, Western Australia's Hamelin Pool is one of only three sites in the w_____ that still has living m_____ stromatolites. The w_____ is twice as salty as normal sea water so few predators or competitors l_____ the microbes' growth.

2 How are stromatolites different from rocks? _____

_____

3 Why is Hamelin Pool a safe environment for stromatolites? _____

_____

4 How could rising sea levels affect the survival of stromatolites? _____

_____

_____

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